

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

MAN OF FEW WORDS

Former Bihar CM Lalu Prasad Yadav's speeches, laced with sarcasm and rustic wit, once held thousands in their thrall. But in recent years, age, ill health and a prison spell for his role in the fodder scam have made the RJD national president a reticent presence. But his words still carry a lot of weight. Last October, Lalu called Bihar Congress in-charge Bhakt Charan Das "*bhakchonhar* (devoid of common sense)". The two parties soon fell apart and contested the bypolls separately. With a verdict in the fodder scam likely this month, the buzz was he might make way for son Tejashwi. Apparently not—when a reporter asked about the widely expected change in guard, Lalu silenced him with one word: "*Moorkh* (fool)!". That's settled then.

Sharks and Elephants



The memoirs of bureaucrat and gold smuggling case accused, M. Sivasankar, have triggered a political storm in Kerala. In *Ashwatthama Is Just an Elephant*, the former principal secretary to CM **Pinarayi Vijayan** claims he was 'framed' by the other accused, including alleged paramour Swapna Suresh. The Opposition has now demanded that the case be reopened. The ruling CPI(M) believes the memoirs were written at the behest of the BJP. They point to another Pinarayi favourite, former vigilance director Jacob Thomas, whose tell-all account, *Swimming with Sharks*, had also skewered the government. The Marxists are now wary of any animal-titled memoirs.

NATURAL CLAIMANT

Gujarat governor **Acharya Devvrat** is said to be the inspiration behind Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman's organic farming push in the budget. An avid practitioner of natural farming, Devvrat's book, *Prakrutik Krishi*, argues that the use of water can be minimised by 70 per cent if we eschew chemicals. Is the governor up for another role at the Centre?





FUNEREAL AIR

Mumbai Congress president **Ashok 'Bhai' Jagtap** was the party's sole representative at Lata Mangeshkar's state funeral on February 6. With social media agog over the 'insult', the party went into damage-control mode, saying its leaders were unwell or out of the city. State Congress president Nana Patole also made a well-publicised visit to the grieving Mangeshkar family the very next day.

Charity Begins at Home



Last year in March, then Rajasthan minister for school education **Govind Singh Dotasra** snubbed teachers who had come seeking his help, asking if they thought the government was a "*nathi ka bada* (charity)". The comeuppance has come now with Dotasra humiliated by the question paper leaks in the Rajasthan Eligibility Entrance Test for Teachers exam. Adding insult to injury, miscreants (allegedly from the opposition BJP) painted a 'Nathi ka Bada' sign outside Dotasra's home.

–Sandeep Unnithan with Amitabh Srivastava, Jeemon Jacob, Kiran D. Tare and Rohit Parihar